MAIR THESIS GUIDELINES

Leiden University · Faculty of Humanities

Based on the MAIR Thesis Supervision Guidelines, last updated May 15, 2026. Deadlines for 2026–2027.

This document is adapted from the MAIR Thesis Supervision Guidelines for student reference. Some content intended for supervisors and second readers has been removed. For the most current information, always consult your supervisor and check Brightspace.

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1. Supervisor Assignment

In the second block of your first semester, you submit a literature review on the basis of which you are assigned to a supervisor by your MAIR specialization (Culture and Politics, European Union Studies, Global Conflict in the Modern Era, Global Order in Historical Perspective, and Global Political Economy). You may indicate a preference for supervisors whose research interests match your own.

Note that supervisor changes are generally approved only in extraordinary circumstances. A change of topic is usually insufficient cause for a change of supervisor.

2. Supervision

Supervision is expected to start upon assignment. Your supervisor will meet with you shortly after assignment to help you set goals, including for the upcoming winter or summer break (during which supervisors are generally not available for supervision).

Minimum meetings: You should meet with your supervisor at least four times:

1. **Introductory meeting:** Discussion of the choice and scope of the thesis topic, the research question, the literature, the source materials, the general approach, and the timetable for submissions.
2. **Introduction/literature review/research design:** Discussion following submission of these sections.
3. **Empirical chapter:** Discussion of an empirical chapter during the intermediate stage.
4. **Final evaluation:** Discussion of the final evaluation.

Feedback: Your supervisor will provide oral or written feedback on the introduction/literature review/research design and at least one subsequent chapter. Supervisors are allowed but not required to read and provide feedback on an entire draft. Your supervisor will communicate their supervision style during the first meeting.

Writing support: If you are struggling with writing in English, contact the faculty's Writing Lab.

Important: Because there is no supervision during the winter and summer breaks, theses cannot be written in their entirety over the break. The student should actively consult their supervisor during the research process. A thesis cannot be submitted for evaluation unless it has been overseen by a supervisor.

3. Research Ethics

You and your supervisor should discuss any potential ethical implications of your research during the initial meeting or when they first arise. Ethical implications should always be considered when the research involves human participants or the use of individually identifiable data. Particular care should be taken with vulnerable groups, such as asylum seekers or citizens of authoritarian regimes. **The program will not allow any thesis research that has the potential to endanger the researcher or participants.**

When conducting interviews:

- Acquire **informed, voluntary consent** from all participants by providing an information sheet that explains the nature and aims of the research project, the implications of participation, and any other considerations that might reasonably influence willingness to participate.
- Protect the **privacy and confidentiality** of participants throughout the research process. Information that may identify individual persons should not be used unless the person has expressly agreed.
- Use a **consent form** that includes acknowledgement that participants have read and understood the information sheet, and details whether they consent to being identified or prefer anonymity.
- Respect the right of individuals to **refuse to participate** or withdraw their consent at any stage without prejudice.

For additional information, see the Code of Ethics available on the Ethics & AI page.

4. Thesis Deadlines and Submission

There is a single deadline to submit the thesis each semester. If the deadline is not met, the next opportunity is the following semester.

Semester	Deadline
Fall 2026	Friday, December 4, 2026
Spring 2027	Friday, June 4, 2027

Email the final thesis to your supervisor, with your second reader and MAthesis@hum.leidenuniv.nl in CC. Submit a printed copy only if your supervisor asks for one. Your supervisor uploads the thesis to Turnitin. Ask for confirmation that your thesis is received and submitted. If you do not receive confirmation, follow up after one week.

Grades are due within four weeks of receipt (January 12, 2027 for the December round). Grading can take longer over the summer.

Extensions

If you need to extend the deadline, you must discuss this with your supervisor and second reader. **Both** need to approve the extension. Please consider that:

- Extension requests must be discussed well before the deadline
- Extensions can result in a later graduation date
- Extensions may prevent participation in the graduation ceremony

If the extension request is not approved, contact stucomair@hum.leidenuniv.nl and consult the Board of Examiners, who base their decision on a hindrance statement from the student counsellors.

Resubmission

Students who fail their thesis are allowed a single retake, which can be submitted at any time. Students who resubmit their revised thesis by the last workday of January (for the December deadline) or August (for the June deadline) can still graduate within the same month.

5. Style and Formatting

- **Maximum word count:** 15,000 words, including all elements (notes, bibliography, and appendices). This is a **hard maximum** and does not allow for a 10% margin.
- One reference style must be used consistently.
- The thesis should:
  - be written in English.
  - be written in Word.
  - use 1.5 line spacing, standard margins, and a standard size 12 font.
  - include the student's name, email, student number, and word count on the title page.
  - include the student number on all subsequent pages.
  - be proofread for spelling and language errors.

6. Assessment

Both the first and second readers will assess the thesis based on the criteria set out below.

Please note that the research *process* is a necessary component for evaluation. The thesis is an independent project, and submission for evaluation requires supervisor oversight.

Quality Criteria

- The thesis should include a clearly formulated research question.
- The thesis should include a critical and analytical report on existing academic debates based on secondary literature.
- The thesis should include an original contribution to academic debates. In principle, the thesis should be of sufficient quality (possibly following some modifications) to be published in an academic journal.
- The thesis should be based on primary sources, if applicable and appropriate.
- The thesis should display the application of concepts and research methods.
- The thesis should display clear structure and proper use of language.
- **Fraud and plagiarism are 'knockout criteria.'** Suspicions thereof must be reported to the Exam Committee.

Fit with Specialization

The thesis should fit your specialization. It is meant to build on a particular set of core courses and electives. You should write a thesis that uses the knowledge, topics, methods, and/or skills gained from following your specific specialization.

Assessment Criteria

Knowledge and Insight: The research question is based on a problem that reflects insight into the key discussions and methods of the field. Assessment also considers whether the problem is clear, relevant, well defined, placed in the existing literature, and original.

Application of Knowledge and Insight: Assessment considers critical analysis of primary sources, use of complex concepts and effective research methods, description and justification of the adopted method, and application of knowledge in broader or multidisciplinary contexts.

Reaching Conclusions: Assessment considers logical and consistent reasoning, well-founded conclusions, and the degree to which the thesis question is answered. It also considers connections to other and future research, social and ethical aspects, and critical reflection on one's role as researcher.

Communication: Assessment considers language use (readability, style, grammar, terminology), structure and layout, and correct use of citations and bibliography.

Learning Skills (Process): Assessment considers the degree of independence, planning and time management, handling of supervisor feedback, and, if applicable, participation in a thesis group.

7. Grade Descriptors

Grade	Class	Description
9–10	A+ Distinction	Outstanding. Excellent understanding of issues and methodologies, original independent thinking, and a rigorous argument using a wide range of sources. At 10, could not be bettered at the MA level.
8–8.9	A Merit	Excellent understanding and independent thought. Strong, well-organized argument using a wide range of sources.
7–7.9	B Merit	Good to very good. Most but not necessarily all of the above.
6–6.9	C Pass	Satisfactory understanding. Reasonable argument with a standard range of sources. Some shortcomings but no fundamental errors.
5.1–5.9		*The faculty does not issue grades in this range.*
3–5.0	F Fail	Inadequate understanding, with substantial omissions or irrelevant material. Poorly conceived.
2–2.9	F Fail	An attempt to answer, but without significant grasp of material or appropriate skills.
0–1.9	U	No answer, totally irrelevant, fundamentally wrong, or plagiarized.

8. Plagiarism

The unacknowledged reproduction of the work, words, or ideas of another person constitutes plagiarism. Students should cite their sources and paraphrase, never 'copy' or moderately edit original text. Any work found to be plagiarized or to contain plagiarism will receive, at the very least, a mark of zero. The maximum penalty is expulsion from the program.

See the Regulations on Plagiarism and the Guidelines for the Use of GenAI in Assessment established by the Faculty of Humanities.